

Basketball - Extension: Positions & Roles

Name: _____

Date: _____

1. Vocabulary (20 words)

#	Word / phrase	Meaning
1	point guard	the position that organises the offense, usually the shortest player
2	shooting guard	a position focused on scoring, often from the perimeter
3	small forward	an all-round position – can score inside and outside
4	power forward	a strong, physical position near the basket
5	center	usually the tallest position, playing closest to the basket
6	perimeter	the outer edge of the scoring area, away from the basket
7	wing	a general term for shooting guards and small forwards, based on where they stand
8	playmaker	a player who focuses on setting up teammates to score
9	catch-and-shoot	receiving a pass and shooting immediately, without dribbling
10	slasher	a player who dribbles quickly toward the basket to attack it
11	the paint	the marked rectangular area right under the basket
12	mid-range (shot)	a shot taken from medium distance, closer than the three-point line
13	three-point shooter	a player skilled at scoring from beyond the three-point line
14	dunk	scoring by jumping and putting the ball directly through the hoop
15	hook shot	a shot taken with a sweeping, sideways arm motion, often used by centers
16	rebound / rebounder	gaining the ball after a missed shot / a player skilled at doing this
17	tempo	the speed/pace at which a team plays
18	basketball IQ	a player's understanding of the game and decision-making
19	physicality	strength and physical contact in play
20	second chance	an extra scoring opportunity created by an offensive rebound

2. Listening - note-taking grid (10-12 min)

Position	Typical size	Main offensive job	Main defensive job	Player example given
Point guard				
Shooting guard				
Small forward				
Power forward				
Center				

Play the video once for students to fill in what they can, then a second time to complete gaps. Check as a class afterwards.

3. True/false check (3-5 min)

- The point guard is usually the tallest player on the team.
- Centers are usually the biggest players, roughly 6'11" to 7 feet tall.
- A shooting guard who focuses on defense and catches-and-shoots is sometimes called a "3 and D" player.
- Power forwards are generally the best three-point shooters on the team.
- According to the video, four of the last five NBA MVPs have been centers.

4. Reading (5 min)

Basketball didn't always look the way it does now. For a long time, each of the five positions had a clear, fixed job: the point guard organised the offense, the center stayed near the basket. Today, the game is far more fluid – many players are hybrids who can do several jobs at once, and a small forward might now shoot like a guard while a power forward might handle the ball like a point guard. Understanding the traditional five roles is still useful, though, because it explains why teams are built the way they are, and why certain body types tend to end up in certain positions.

Comprehension questions: 1. What does the text say has changed about basketball positions over time? 2. Why is it still useful to know the traditional five roles?

5. Writing (5-7 min)

Choose one: - **A.** Write a short player profile (6-8 sentences) for an imaginary player: their position, height, playing style, and main strengths – using at least 6 words from the list above. - **B.** Compare two positions of your choice (e.g. point guard vs center) in 5-6 sentences, focusing on what's different about their job on the court.

6. Speaking / discussion (5-7 min)

In pairs or small groups: "*Which of the five positions do you think would suit you, and why?*" Encourage them to justify with at least 3 vocabulary words (height, playing style, offensive/defensive role). Good natural bridge into personality/self-description language too.

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About this video

How basketball positions work – <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Wk8PrzMLGEE>
(The Athletic) Two things worth flagging before you use it:

1. **American source, American sport, but the narrator's accent is actually British-sounding** – an interesting mismatch worth naming with the group: American publisher (The Athletic), NBA players and culture throughout (Steph Curry, LeBron James, Kobe Bryant, Michael Jordan, Tim Duncan), even a comparison to an American football quarterback for the point guard – but the voice itself doesn't read as American. Might be worth a one-line gloss on the American football reference if your students don't follow it.
2. **Heights are shown on screen in both imperial and metric** (e.g. 6'11" and the cm equivalent) – useful if you want to fold in a unit-conversion angle later, separate from this activity. Worth keeping in mind alongside your existing imperial measurements listening material.
3. **Heavy on-screen text.** Since captions/graphics are visible throughout, a gap-fill from the audio won't really test listening – students can just read the answer off the screen. I've built the comprehension task around **note-taking** instead (below), which forces genuine listening even with the visuals present, plus tasks that don't depend on the transcript wording at all.

7. Game (10 min)

"Guess the Position" - One student privately picks a position and describes it (build, offensive job, defensive job, maybe a comparison to a player) *without naming it*. - The rest of the group guesses which position is being described. First correct guesser describes the next one.

Alternative - "Position Draft" (small groups, more negotiation-heavy) - Give each group a short list of 5 invented player descriptions (build, skills, personality). In English, groups discuss and assign each player to a position, justifying their choices to the class. Good for recycling vocabulary in a more open-ended, argumentative way – closer to real discussion than a guessing game.

Since this is denser and culturally different (American, explainer-style rather than coaching commands), it works best as a one-off extension slot rather than folded into the main basketball session – exactly as planned.

About this activity

B1-B2 only – the main "Understanding Your Coach" basketball activity stays as the core lesson for everyone ~30–35 min – this one's richer and denser, worth its own slot rather than squeezing into the main session

1. Vocabulary (20 words)

Paste into the Daily Vocabulary Generator as usual.

2. Listening - note-taking grid (10-12 min)

Give students this grid before playing the video. This works even with on-screen text visible, because copying captions won't fill in most of these columns – they have to actually listen and synthesise.

4. Reading (5 min)

Short original text – hand out or project.

3. True/false check (3-5 min)

1. The point guard is usually the tallest player on the team. → False – shortest
2. Centers are usually the biggest players, roughly 6'11" to 7 feet tall. → True
3. A shooting guard who focuses on defense and catches-and-shoots is sometimes called a "3 and D" player. → True
4. Power forwards are generally the best three-point shooters on the team. → False – decent mid-range, but not usually strong three-point shooters
5. According to the video, four of the last five NBA MVPs have been centers. → True